

# Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

## Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

## Customer Details

Name: S Bhargava

Address: 37 Furzedown Road Sutton SM2 5QF

## Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer objects to the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I am writing to formally object to the above planning application. While the provision of community facilities is generally supported in principle, this specific proposal fails to meet the stringent requirements for community cohesion and social integration set out in the National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) December 2024 and supported by the findings of the 2016 Casey Review.

### 1. Failure to Meet NPPF (2024) Requirements for Social Interaction

Under Paragraph 96(a) of the NPPF (Dec 2024), planning decisions must aim to achieve healthy, inclusive, and safe places that "promote social interaction, including opportunities for meetings between people who might not otherwise come into contact with each other."

The current proposal is designed as a specialized, single-use faith facility. By its nature and scale, it does not facilitate the broad-spectrum social mixing required by the Framework. Instead of creating a "shared space," it risks creating a "closed space." Furthermore, Paragraph 98 requires that planning for shared spaces must benefit "all sections of the community." Given that this proposal serves a narrow demographic, it fails the "all sections" test.

### 2. Risk of Social Segregation (The Casey Review)

The Casey Review (2016), which remains a cornerstone of UK integration policy, warns explicitly against the formation of "parallel lives." The Review highlights how concentrated faith facilities can accelerate residential clustering and reduce everyday mixing between different ethnic and religious groups.

The proposed development, due to its [size/intensity of use], risks consolidating a faith-based enclave in this part of Sutton. This directly contradicts the Borough's duty to foster a cohesive community where residents from different backgrounds interact regularly. The Casey Review argues that integration is a "two-way street"; this proposal, however, represents a "one-way" use

of land that offers little to the wider non-aligned community.

### 3. Disproportionality Relative to Local Need (2021 Census)

According to the 2021 Census data for Sutton, the religious landscape of the borough is highly diverse but also significantly secular:

Christian: 45.8%

No Religion: 32.3%

Muslim: 7.0%

Hindu: 7.0%

With nearly one-third (32.3%) of Sutton's population identifying as having "No Religion," there is a demonstrable and greater strategic need for neutral, secular community spaces that serve the entire population. Granting a large-scale, single-faith facility for a demographic representing 7% of the borough is disproportionate, especially if that facility does not provide significant, guaranteed access for the 93% of residents who do not share that faith. In addition there are already faith worship places (6 in total) available in the borough)

The proposal in its current form undermines the "Cohesion" mandate of the NPPF 2024 and ignores the integration warnings of the Casey Review. It fails to reflect the actual demographic needs of Sutton as evidenced by the 2021 Census. I urge the Council to refuse this application and instead prioritize land uses that offer genuine, inclusive interaction for all residents.